military machine in 2001, India voluntarily stopped such partisan support and attempted to engage most Afghan political factions. It also shifted gears from providing military support to investing in soft sectors such as post-war reconstruction and infrastructural development. Ranging from building roads, hospitals and schools, India provided a range of small development projects for different parts of the war-torn country. Nonetheless, many Afghans criticise India for lacking a coherent policy towards their country and being an unreliable regional partner, Western capitals have been unsure about the extent to which expanded Indian presence in Afghanistan (however attractive it may sound from a Western exchequer's perspective) helps the cause of peace in the region, and Islamabad blames India for destabilising Pakistan's fragile provinces of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA), and Baluchistan, via Afghanistan—all at the same time.

In October 2011, India signed a comprehensive Strategic Partnership Agreement (SPA) with the Afghan government. Representing another shift, the SPA indicated New Delhi's willingness to depart from its traditional policy of boycotting the Afghan Taliban. Critically, the SPA expressed India's decision to support an Afghan-led reconciliation process instead of getting embroiled in factional politics. Why did New Delhi agree to sign an agreement that challenged its declared anti-Taliban stand? Despite continuity in its traditional policy of engaging Kabul on friendly terms, New Delhi's Afghanistan policy underwent conspicuous shifts during the 1979–2015 period. These shifts have been critical in shaping South Asia's regional security and political dynamics. In fact, given the precarious security situation in and around Afghanistan today, India's choice of friends and enemies in that country, as well as the ways in which New Delhi decides to deal with them, will have far reaching consequences. A good way to ascertain India's prospective behavior on these questions, then, is to deconstruct its recent past. This book explains the sources of change in India's Afghanistan policy since the Soviet intervention, what this shows about India's Afghanistan policy specifically (a rising India in general), and, based on this examination, what can one expect from India in the future.

Partisans and conciliators